



Benevolent House ACADEMY

Where Foundations Become Futures

EMPLOYEE HANDBOOK

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*This handbook is the property of Benevolent House Academy Inc.
All employees must read, understand, and sign a separate acknowledgment page.*

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SECTION 1: WELCOME AND MISSION

Welcome to Benevolent House Academy. We are a licensed childcare center in Red Oak, Texas, licensed by the Texas Health and Human Services Commission (HHSC) Child Care Regulation (CCR) division, Operation #1832672. We are licensed for 24-hour care for children 6 weeks through 13 years of age, and we are opening our programs in phases. Today we provide full-time infant, toddler, and preschool care for children 6 weeks through 5 years of age, Monday through Friday, 6:00 AM to 6:00 PM, and we are closed 16 days each year (see Section 6). Weekend care, evening care, and school-age summer care are coming soon. Our licensed capacity is 52 children with an infant capacity of 9.

Our Mission

Benevolent House Academy provides trauma-informed, developmentally appropriate care in a safe, nurturing environment where every child is valued, supported, and empowered to grow. We believe that every child deserves to feel safe, seen, and celebrated.

Our Core Values

- **Safety First.** The physical and emotional safety of every child is our highest priority.
- **Trauma-Informed Care.** We understand that behavior is communication. We respond with empathy, consistency, and connection.
- **Respect.** We treat every child, family, and team member with dignity and respect.
- **Accountability.** We hold ourselves to the highest standards of professionalism, compliance, and integrity.
- **Partnership with Families.** We are partners with parents in supporting their children.

Organizational Structure

Benevolent House Academy Inc. is a corporation governed by a Board of Directors. The organizational structure is as follows:

- **Head of Governing Body / Executive Director:** Tanya Orr
- **Chief Operating Officer:** Christopher Orr
- **Directors:** Responsible for daily on-site operations, staff supervision, compliance, and communication with licensing. Vanessa Wright and Haddie Mashburn serve as Directors. Together with the Executive Director and COO, they make up the BHA leadership team.
- **Caregivers:** Responsible for the direct care, supervision, and education of children in their assigned classroom.

The Directors report to the Executive Director. When one Director is absent, the other assumes the director role. All caregivers report to the Directors.

Handbook Review and Updates

This Employee Handbook is reviewed and updated annually by the Executive Director. When updates are made, all employees will be notified of the changes and will be asked to sign a new acknowledgment. The most current version of the handbook is always maintained at the center and available for employee review. Employees are responsible for staying informed of any updates to center policies.

SECTION 2: EMPLOYMENT RELATIONSHIP

At-Will Employment

Employment at Benevolent House Academy is at-will. This means that either the employee or the employer may end the employment relationship at any time, with or without cause, and with or without notice. Nothing in this handbook creates a contract of employment or guarantees employment for any specific duration.

Equal Employment Opportunity

Benevolent House Academy is an equal opportunity employer. We do not discriminate on the basis of race, color, religion, sex, national origin, age, disability, genetic information, veteran status, or any other characteristic protected by federal, state, or local law. This policy applies to all terms and conditions of employment, including hiring, placement, promotion, termination, compensation, and training.

Reasonable Accommodations

Benevolent House Academy will provide reasonable accommodations to qualified individuals with disabilities in accordance with the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA). Employees who need an accommodation should notify the Director or Executive Director.

Harassment-Free Workplace

Benevolent House Academy is committed to providing a work environment free of harassment of any kind. Harassment based on race, color, religion, sex, national origin, age, disability, or any other protected characteristic is strictly prohibited. Any employee who experiences or witnesses harassment should report it immediately to the Director or Executive Director. Reports will be investigated promptly and confidentially to the extent possible. Retaliation against any employee who reports harassment in good faith is strictly prohibited.

SECTION 3: HIRING AND ONBOARDING

Background Checks

All employees must undergo and pass a criminal background check through the HHSC background check system before their first day of employment. Background checks are repeated every 5 years thereafter. Employees are required to notify the Director immediately if they are arrested or charged with a crime at any point during their employment. The center notifies licensing no later than two business days after learning of such an arrest or charge, as required by TAC 746.305.

Required Documentation

Before beginning employment, each employee must provide the following:

- Completed employment application
- Valid government-issued photo identification
- Social Security card or other work authorization documents (I-9 compliance)
- Proof of education (diploma, transcripts, or degree as applicable to the position)
- Documentation of any current certifications (CPR, First Aid, CDA, etc.)
- Signed acknowledgment of this Employee Handbook
- Completed Form 2947, Personnel Information Record (TAC 746.901)
- Completed W-4 and direct deposit authorization forms

Orientation

All new employees complete a comprehensive orientation within 7 days of hire and before having unsupervised access to a child in care. The orientation covers minimum standards, center policies, trauma-informed care, child abuse prevention and reporting, emergency procedures, health and safety, and daily operations. Caregivers who are not exempt complete 24 clock hours of pre-service training: 8 clock hours before being counted in the child-to-caregiver ratio and the remaining 16 clock hours within 90 days of employment. The full orientation curriculum is maintained at the center and available for review by the licensing representative.

Probationary Period

All new employees serve a 90-day probationary period beginning on the first day of employment. During this period, the Director will evaluate the employee on attendance, reliability, job performance, professionalism, and ability to work with children and families. Employment may be ended at any time during the probationary period. Successful completion of the probationary period does not change the at-will nature of employment.

SECTION 4: WORK SCHEDULES AND ATTENDANCE

Hours of Operation

Benevolent House Academy is open Monday through Friday, 6:00 AM to 6:00 PM, and is closed 16 days each year (see Section 6). The center is licensed for 24-hour care. When weekend and evening care begin, those hours will be added here.

Scheduling

Work schedules are set by the Director and are based on enrollment, child-to-caregiver ratio requirements, and operational needs. Schedules fall within operating hours, Monday through Friday, 6:00 AM to 6:00 PM. When weekend and evening care begin, schedules may also

include those shifts. Employees are expected to be available for the shift(s) agreed upon at the time of hire. Schedule changes require advance approval from the Director.

Attendance and Punctuality

Reliable attendance is essential to maintaining safe child-to-caregiver ratios and providing consistent care. Employees are expected to arrive on time and ready to work at the start of their scheduled shift. If an employee is unable to report to work or will be late, they must notify the Director as early as possible and no later than one hour before the start of their scheduled shift.

Tardiness

An employee is considered tardy if they clock in more than 5 minutes after their scheduled start time. Tardiness is tracked through Brightwheel, which timestamps every clock-in. The following progressive consequences apply on a rolling 90-day basis:

- **3 tardies in 90 days:** Verbal warning. The Director will meet with the employee to discuss the pattern. The warning is documented in the employee's personnel file. The employee will be informed that the tardy is being documented and that continued tardiness will result in further action.
- **5 tardies in 90 days:** Written warning. The employee signs the warning, which is placed in their personnel file.
- **7 tardies in 90 days:** Final written warning and suspension without pay for 3 days. The employee is advised that any further tardiness will result in termination.
- **Continued tardiness after final warning:** Termination.

At every step, the employee is made aware that the tardy is being documented. There are no surprise consequences. Brightwheel timestamps serve as the objective record.

No-Call, No-Show

Failure to report to work and failure to notify the Director constitutes a no-call, no-show. A single no-call, no-show may result in immediate termination because of the direct impact on child safety and ratio compliance. A true emergency, such as a hospital stay, that keeps the employee or a family member from calling is not treated as a no-call, no-show when the employee contacts the Director as soon as they are able.

Breaks

Employees scheduled to work 6 or more consecutive hours are entitled to a 30-minute unpaid meal break. Breaks are scheduled by the Director to ensure that child-to-caregiver ratios are maintained at all times. Employees must not leave children unsupervised to take a break. If a break cannot be provided due to staffing constraints, the employee will be compensated for the time worked.

SECTION 5: COMPENSATION AND PAYROLL

Pay Structure

The Director position is a salaried, exempt position. All caregiver and support staff positions are hourly, non-exempt positions. Pay rates are discussed and agreed upon at the time of hire and documented in the employee's offer letter.

Pay Schedule

Employees are paid biweekly (every other Friday). Each pay period covers the two weeks ending on the Saturday before payday. If a payday falls on a holiday, employees will be paid on the last business day before the holiday.

Timekeeping

Hourly employees are required to accurately record all hours worked. Employees must clock in at the start of their shift and clock out at the end of their shift. Falsifying time records is grounds for immediate termination.

Overtime

Hourly employees who work more than 40 hours in a single workweek are compensated at one and one-half times their regular hourly rate for all hours over 40, in compliance with the Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA). Overtime must be approved in advance by the Director. Working unauthorized overtime may result in corrective action.

Direct Deposit

Benevolent House Academy encourages all employees to enroll in direct deposit. Employees who do not enroll in direct deposit will receive a paper check on payday.

SECTION 6: HOLIDAYS AND LEAVE

Holiday Closures

Benevolent House Academy is closed to children on the following 16 days each year. Holiday closures are unpaid days for hourly employees. The two staff in-service days are scheduled workdays for all employees, used for training and planning.

- New Year's Day
- Martin Luther King Jr. Day
- Presidents' Day (staff in-service day, beginning 2027)
- Good Friday
- Memorial Day
- Juneteenth
- Independence Day (July 4th)
- Labor Day

- Second Monday in October (staff in-service day, beginning 2027)
- Wednesday before Thanksgiving
- Thanksgiving Day
- Day After Thanksgiving
- December 23
- Christmas Eve
- Christmas Day
- New Year's Eve

If a holiday falls on a Saturday, the center will be closed on the preceding Friday. If a holiday falls on a Sunday, the center will be closed on the following Monday. When Halloween falls on a weekday, the center closes at 5:00 PM.

Paid Time Off (PTO)

Director positions receive 5 days of paid time off (PTO) per PTO year, which runs from each director's hire anniversary. PTO may be used for any reason, including illness, bereavement, vacation, or personal needs. Directors also receive one scheduled day off every other month on an alternating schedule, so that only one director is out in any month; this day does not count against PTO. PTO days and alternating days off do not carry over to the next year and are not paid out at separation. Caregiver and support staff positions may earn paid days off through the Earned Paid Days incentive (see Section 24). Unpaid time off may be requested in writing at least two weeks in advance and is granted at the discretion of the Director based on staffing and ratio needs.

Jury Duty

Employees summoned for jury duty will be granted unpaid time off for the duration of service. Employees must provide a copy of the jury summons to the Director as soon as it is received.

Bereavement

Employees may request up to 3 days of unpaid bereavement leave for the death of an immediate family member (spouse, child, parent, sibling, grandparent, or grandchild). Additional time may be approved at the discretion of the Executive Director.

Family and Medical Leave Act (FMLA)

Benevolent House Academy does not currently meet the employee threshold for the Family and Medical Leave Act (FMLA). If the center reaches 50 or more employees within a 75-mile radius, FMLA provisions will be incorporated into this handbook and communicated to all staff at that time.

SECTION 7: PROFESSIONAL CONDUCT, DRESS CODE, AND APPEARANCE

Professional Conduct

Employees of Benevolent House Academy are expected to conduct themselves in a professional manner at all times. This includes treating all children, families, visitors, and coworkers with courtesy and respect. Employees represent the center in all interactions and are expected to uphold the center's mission, values, and reputation.

Prohibited Workplace Conduct

The following conduct is strictly prohibited and will result in immediate termination on the first offense. There are no warnings for these behaviors.

- **Profanity and vulgar language.** The use of profanity, curse words, vulgar language, or obscene gestures is prohibited in the workplace at all times, whether directed at a child, parent, coworker, or used in general conversation. Children hear and repeat what adults say, and families expect a professional environment. This applies in classrooms, common areas, break rooms, the parking lot, and anywhere on center property or during center activities.
- **Yelling and shouting.** Raising your voice in anger, yelling, screaming, or shouting at a child, parent, coworker, or visitor is prohibited. Caregivers may use a firm, clear voice for safety (such as calling out to stop a child from running into danger), but aggressive or hostile yelling is never acceptable.
- **Gossiping.** Gossiping about coworkers, families, or children is prohibited. Gossip includes spreading rumors, sharing another employee's personal information, making negative comments about a coworker behind their back, speculating about families' personal lives, and engaging in conversations that create division, cliques, or a hostile work environment. If you have a concern about a coworker, bring it to the Director through the grievance process (Section 27). Do not discuss it with other employees.
- **Fighting.** Physical altercations of any kind, including pushing, shoving, hitting, or any physical contact made in anger, will result in immediate termination.

Political Discussions

Political discussions, debates, and commentary are not permitted in the workplace at any time, including in classrooms, common areas, break rooms, and in the presence of families. Benevolent House Academy serves families of all backgrounds and beliefs. The workplace is not a forum for political expression. This includes verbal discussions, displaying political materials, wearing political items not covered by the dress code, and posting political content on center devices or in center spaces. This policy applies equally to all political viewpoints. Violation of this policy will result in corrective action up to and including termination.

Dress Code

Employees must arrive to each shift in clean, neat, modest, and professional attire that is appropriate for working with young children. Childcare is active work that involves sitting on the floor, bending, lifting, outdoor play, and close physical contact with children. Your clothing must support safe, active caregiving at all times.

Required

- Closed-toe, non-slip shoes at all times. No flip-flops, sandals, slides, open-toe shoes, or high heels.
- BHA-branded shirts are the required top and must be worn during all operating hours so that parents, visitors, and children can easily identify authorized staff members. Until BHA shirts are issued, employees must wear solid-color polo shirts or plain crew-neck shirts in neutral or professional colors.
- Each employee receives 3 BHA-branded shirts at no cost upon hire. BHA shirts are center property. Upon resignation or termination, all BHA shirts must be returned to the Director within 5 business days of the employee's last day in clean, wearable condition without irreparable damage (no stains, cuts, tears, holes, or alterations). If shirts are not returned within 5 business days, or are returned with irreparable damage, the replacement cost of each unreturned or damaged shirt will be deducted from the employee's final paycheck to the extent permitted by Texas law.
- Pants, capris, or knee-length shorts that allow full range of movement. Jeans are acceptable if they are clean and free of holes or rips.
- All clothing must be clean, free of stains, wrinkle-free, and in good repair (no holes, tears, or fraying).

Prohibited

- Tight-fitting, body-hugging, or form-fitting clothing (leggings, spandex, or yoga pants may not be worn as standalone bottoms; they may be worn under a tunic or top that extends to mid-thigh or longer).
- Revealing clothing of any kind: low-cut tops, spaghetti straps, halter tops, crop tops, midriff-baring shirts, sheer or see-through fabric, or clothing that exposes undergarments.
- Shorts or skirts above mid-thigh.
- Clothing with offensive, vulgar, political, or inappropriate language, logos, or images.
- Pajamas, loungewear, or sleepwear (this applies to every shift, including evening and overnight shifts when offered).
- Athletic wear (sweatpants, basketball shorts, track suits) unless approved for a specific outdoor activity by the Director.

Jewelry and Accessories

Jewelry and accessories must not pose a safety hazard to children. Children grab, pull, and put things in their mouths. Small stud earrings are permitted. No large hoops, dangling earrings, or long necklaces that a child could grab or pull. Bracelets must be snug-fitting or removed during caregiving. Rings should be minimal. Lanyards, if worn, must have a breakaway clasp for safety.

Hair

Hair must be clean, neat, and professionally maintained. Hair color must be a natural tone (black, brown, blonde, auburn, red, gray, or similar natural shades). Unnatural hair colors such

as bright pink, blue, green, purple, or neon shades are not permitted. Hair that is long enough to fall in a child's face or into food during mealtimes must be pulled back and secured. Head coverings worn for religious or cultural reasons are always permitted.

Nails

Fingernails must be kept at a moderate length that does not interfere with caregiving tasks such as diapering, feeding, buttoning clothing, or handling small objects. Excessively long nails, sharp nail tips, or nail embellishments (charms, jewels, 3D designs) that could scratch a child or detach and become a choking hazard are not permitted.

Piercings

Piercings must not pose a safety hazard to children. Children grab, pull, and put things in their mouths. The following guidelines apply:

- Small stud earrings are permitted. No large hoops, dangling earrings, or earrings that a child could grab or pull (see Jewelry and Accessories above).
- A small stud nose piercing is permitted (one per nostril maximum).
- No septum rings, lip rings, tongue piercings, eyebrow piercings, or any other facial piercings that could be grabbed by a child or that could dislodge and become a choking hazard.
- Gauges and plugs must be solid and flush-fitting. Open tunnel gauges that a child could hook a finger through are not permitted.
- Body piercings that are not visible during normal work attire do not require disclosure or removal.

Tattoos

Visible tattoos must not depict violence, weapons, profanity, drug or alcohol use, nudity, gang-related imagery, or anything else that is inappropriate for a childcare setting. If a visible tattoo falls into any of these categories, it must be covered during work hours.

Fragrance

Strong perfumes, colognes, and scented lotions should be avoided. Many children have sensitivities or allergies, and strong scents can cause discomfort or allergic reactions.

Enforcement

The Director may send an employee home (without pay for hourly staff) to change if their attire or appearance does not meet these standards. Time spent going home to change is not compensated. Repeated dress code or appearance violations will result in corrective action.

SECTION 8: CELL PHONE AND PERSONAL DEVICE POLICY

IMPORTANT: Personal cell phones and personal electronic devices are not permitted on the classroom floor, in outdoor play areas, or in any area where children are present. This policy is strictly enforced and exists to ensure active supervision of children at all times.

Personal cell phones must be stored in the employee's personal bag, locker, or in the office during working hours. Employees may use their personal phones during scheduled breaks in designated break areas only (the office or staff break area).

If an employee is expecting an urgent personal call (such as a family emergency), they must notify the Director in advance. The Director will arrange for the employee to receive the call in the office. The center's main phone number, (469) 807-1221, is available for family members to reach employees in case of a true emergency during work hours.

Consequences

First violation: Verbal warning documented in the employee's personnel file. Second violation: Written warning. Third violation: Suspension or termination at the discretion of the Director and Executive Director. Any instance of a cell phone being used while actively supervising children may result in immediate termination due to the direct safety risk.

SECTION 9: TOBACCO, VAPING, AND SMOKE-FREE WORKPLACE

Benevolent House Academy is a completely smoke-free and tobacco-free facility. Smoking, vaping, and the use of electronic cigarettes, cigars, pipes, smokeless tobacco, or any other tobacco or nicotine product is strictly prohibited inside the center building, on the center grounds (including the parking lot, outdoor play area, and all surrounding property), in any vehicle used for center transportation, and in the presence of children at any time (including during field trips and off-site activities).

This policy applies to all employees, volunteers, parents, and visitors. Employees who wish to use tobacco or nicotine products may do so only during scheduled breaks, off the center premises, and out of sight of children and families. Employees must wash their hands before returning to the classroom after using tobacco products. Violation of this policy will result in corrective action up to and including termination.

SECTION 10: DRUG AND ALCOHOL POLICY

IMPORTANT: Benevolent House Academy maintains a zero-tolerance policy for drug and alcohol use. The safety of the children in our care depends on every employee being alert, sober, and fully capable of performing their duties at all times.

Prohibited Conduct

The following conduct is strictly prohibited and will result in immediate termination:

- Reporting to work or being on the center premises while under the influence of alcohol, illegal drugs, or any substance that impairs judgment, coordination, or the ability to safely care for children.

- Using, possessing, distributing, selling, or manufacturing alcohol, illegal drugs, or drug paraphernalia on center property, in center vehicles, or during any work-related activity (including field trips).
- Using prescription or over-the-counter medications in a manner that impairs the ability to safely perform job duties. Employees taking medication that may cause drowsiness, impaired coordination, or slowed reaction time must notify the Director before their shift.

Right to Test

Benevolent House Academy reserves the right to require drug and/or alcohol testing under the following circumstances: pre-employment (as a condition of hire), reasonable suspicion (when a supervisor has reasonable suspicion based on observable signs such as slurred speech, impaired coordination, erratic behavior, or the smell of alcohol), and post-accident (following any workplace accident or incident involving a child). Refusal to submit to a test when requested will be treated as a positive result and will result in immediate termination.

SECTION 11: CONFIDENTIALITY AND PRIVACY

Employees have access to confidential information about children, families, and coworkers. All such information must be kept strictly confidential. Confidential information includes children's enrollment records, medical information, allergy information, and emergency contacts; family financial information, custody documents, and court orders; employee personnel records, pay rates, and performance evaluations; center financial and operational information; and any information shared by a parent in confidence.

Confidential information may only be shared with individuals who have a legitimate need to know in order to perform their job duties or as required by law (such as mandatory reporting of child abuse or neglect). Discussing confidential information about children or families outside of the workplace, including on social media, is strictly prohibited and is grounds for immediate termination.

Photographs and Media

Employees may not photograph or video record children on personal devices at any time. All photographs and videos of children are taken using center-approved devices (Brightwheel or a center-owned camera) and are used only for parent communication, center documentation, or marketing with prior written parental consent.

Center Property

All equipment, materials, and supplies purchased by or provided by Benevolent House Academy are center property. This includes laptops, tablets, iPads, cameras, cell phones issued by the center, classroom materials, curriculum kits, books, office supplies (pens, pencils, staplers, paper, binders), cleaning supplies, first aid supplies, kitchen equipment, and any other items purchased with center funds.

Center property must remain at the center unless specifically authorized by the Director for a work-related purpose (such as transporting a first aid kit on a field trip). Removing center

property from the premises without authorization is considered theft and is grounds for immediate termination.

Employees are responsible for the reasonable care of center property assigned to them or used during their duties. Intentional damage to center property will result in immediate termination. The cost of repair or replacement may be deducted from the employee's final paycheck to the extent permitted by Texas law.

Upon resignation or termination, all center property in the employee's possession (including keys, access cards, BHA shirts, and any equipment or materials) must be returned to the Director on or before the employee's last day. Failure to return center property will be treated as outlined in the BHA shirt return policy above, with replacement costs deducted from the final paycheck to the extent permitted by Texas law.

SECTION 12: VISITOR ACCESS POLICY

General Visitor Procedures

- All exterior doors remain locked during operating hours. Visitors must be admitted by a staff member.
- Every visitor must sign in at the front desk, providing their name, date, time of arrival, and purpose of visit.
- Every visitor must present a valid government-issued photo ID upon request.
- Visitors must sign out upon departure.
- No visitor is permitted unsupervised access to any area where children are present.

Parent Access

Parents of enrolled children may access the center during operating hours to drop off or pick up their child. Parents are always welcome to observe their child's classroom. However, parents must follow the sign-in/sign-out procedures and must not disrupt classroom activities. Custody orders and restricted pickup lists are maintained in each child's file and communicated to all caregivers.

Licensing and Regulatory Visits

HHSC Child Care Regulation inspectors, DFPS investigators, and other authorized regulatory representatives have the right to access the facility at any time during operating hours. Employees must cooperate fully and notify the Director immediately when a regulatory representative arrives.

Unauthorized Persons

If any employee is uncertain about a visitor's identity or authorization, they must not allow the person access to children. The employee should direct the visitor to the front desk and notify the Director immediately. If a person refuses to leave or poses a threat, employees should call 911.

SECTION 13: CHILD-TO-CAREGIVER RATIOS

Maintaining proper child-to-caregiver ratios is a legal requirement under Texas Administrative Code Chapter 746 and is essential to the safety of children in our care. Ratios must be maintained at all times, including during indoor activities, outdoor play, meals, naps, transitions, field trips, and emergencies.

Room	Age Group	Max Children	Ratio	Min Staff
Seedlings (Classroom 0)	6 weeks - 11 months	4	1:4	1
Discoverers (Classroom 1)	12 - 17 months	5	1:5	1
Explorers (Classroom 2)	18 - 35 months	11 (no more than 9 under age 2)	1:9 if any child is under 2; 1:11 if all are 2	1 (2 when more than 9 children and any child is under 2)
Innovators (Classroom 3)	3 years	15	1:15	1
Scholars (Classroom 4)	4 - 5 years	17	1:18	1

IMPORTANT: If a caregiver needs to leave the classroom for any reason (restroom, break, retrieving supplies), they must first arrange for another qualified caregiver to cover their classroom. A classroom must never be left without a caregiver who meets ratio requirements.

Ratios follow TAC 746.1601 for single-age groups: 1:4 for infants 0-11 months, 1:5 for 12-17 months, 1:9 for 18-23 months, 1:11 for 2-year-olds, 1:15 for 3-year-olds, and 1:18 for 4-year-olds. In mixed-age classrooms, BHA bases the ratio on the youngest child in the group, which is stricter than the state's specified-age formula in TAC 746.1603. The total licensed capacity is 52 children with an infant capacity of 9 (Seedlings and Discoverers). At full capacity: 52 children + 6 caregivers + 1 director = 59 persons, which matches the Certificate of Occupancy. When school-age care begins, the school-age ratios (1:22 for 5-year-olds and 1:26 for ages 6 through 13) will be added here.

SECTION 14: DISCIPLINE AND CHILD GUIDANCE

Benevolent House Academy uses a trauma-informed, relationship-based approach to child guidance. We believe that behavior is communication and that children do well when they can. Caregivers are trained to respond to challenging behavior with empathy, consistency, and connection.

Approved Guidance Techniques

- Positive reinforcement and encouragement
- Emotion coaching (helping children name and regulate their feelings)
- Redirection to appropriate activities
- Setting clear, consistent limits
- Offering age-appropriate choices
- Natural and logical consequences
- Modeling appropriate behavior

- Co-regulation (caregiver remaining calm and present to help a dysregulated child return to calm)
- Brief supervised separation from the group when necessary (not to exceed one minute per year of the child's age)

Strictly Prohibited Methods

IMPORTANT: The following methods are strictly prohibited and will result in immediate corrective action up to and including termination. There are no exceptions.

- Corporal punishment of any kind (spanking, hitting, slapping, pinching, shaking, biting, or any form of physical punishment)
- Verbal abuse (threats, humiliation, profanity, shaming, or derogatory remarks directed at a child)
- Punishment associated with food, rest, or toileting (withholding meals or snacks, forcing a child to stay on a cot, refusing access to a restroom)
- Placing a child in a dark room, locked room, or any enclosed space as punishment
- Requiring physical exercise as punishment
- Any form of discipline that is frightening or humiliating to a child
- Allowing other children to discipline or punish a child

These prohibitions are reviewed with all employees during orientation and annually thereafter. Any employee who witnesses a prohibited discipline method must report it immediately to the Director. Failure to report is itself a violation of this policy.

Behavior Classification and Response

To ensure consistency and transparency, Benevolent House Academy classifies behaviors into three levels. The center's response is proportional to the severity and frequency of the behavior.

Level 1 Behaviors (Low-Level Concerns): These are developmentally typical behaviors that are addressed through routine guidance techniques. Examples include not following classroom rules, difficulty sharing or taking turns, minor verbal conflicts with peers, crying or whining, and refusing to participate in activities. Response: Caregivers use redirection, emotion coaching, and positive reinforcement. Parents are informed through daily reports if the behavior is persistent.

Level 2 Behaviors (Moderate Concerns): These are behaviors that are disruptive, persistent, or that may cause minor harm to the child, other children, or staff. Examples include biting, hitting, kicking, or pushing other children; throwing objects at others; persistent defiance or refusal to follow safety rules; destructive behavior toward classroom materials or property; and spitting at others. Response: The behavior is documented in an incident report. The parent is notified on the day of occurrence. If the behavior is recurring, the behavior escalation process is initiated.

Level 3 Behaviors (Serious Safety Concerns): These are behaviors that pose an immediate safety risk to the child, other children, or staff. Examples include severe physical aggression causing injury to another child or staff member, biting that breaks the skin, elopement (leaving

the classroom or building without permission), self-injurious behavior, and threatening behavior toward staff or children. Response: The child is immediately separated from the group in a supervised area. The parent is contacted for immediate pickup. The behavior escalation process is initiated at the appropriate step based on severity.

Suspension and Expulsion

Benevolent House Academy is committed to working with families before considering suspension or disenrollment. If a child's behavior is a concern, the following process will be followed:

- **Step 1: Parent Conference.** The Director and caregiver will meet with the parent to discuss the behavior, identify possible causes, and develop a plan together.
- **Step 2: Written Behavior Plan.** If the behavior continues, a written behavior plan will be developed in partnership with the family.
- **Step 3: Temporary Suspension.** If the behavior plan does not result in improvement and the child's behavior continues to pose a safety risk, the child may be temporarily suspended (1 to 5 days).
- **Step 4: Disenrollment.** If all reasonable interventions have been exhausted and the behavior continues to pose a persistent safety risk, the center may disenroll the child. Parents will receive 5 business days of written notice.

In cases where a child's behavior poses an immediate danger to themselves or others, the center may require immediate parent pickup and begin the escalation process at Step 3 or Step 4 based on severity.

Biting Policy

Benevolent House Academy recognizes that biting is a common, developmentally typical behavior in infants and toddlers. Young children may bite because they lack the language to express frustration, excitement, or sensory needs. Our response to biting is rooted in understanding the reason behind the behavior while keeping all children safe.

- **First incident:** The caregiver separates the children, comforts the child who was bitten, and provides first aid. The biting child is redirected using age-appropriate guidance. Both families are notified on the day of occurrence through an incident report. The caregiver documents the circumstances to identify patterns.
- **Second incident (or emerging pattern):** The Director reviews documentation for patterns. The caregiver adjusts the classroom environment to reduce triggers. The parent of the biting child is contacted for a conference (Step 1).
- **Third incident or continued pattern:** A written behavior plan (Step 2) is developed with the family. The plan may include shadow supervision, sensory alternatives, schedule modifications, or referral to Early Childhood Intervention (ECI) or a behavioral specialist.
- **Persistent biting after the plan is in place:** Temporary suspension (Step 3) may be used. Disenrollment (Step 4) is considered only after all reasonable interventions have been exhausted.

At every step, caregivers respond with empathy and without shaming. Biting is never treated as willful misbehavior in infants and toddlers.

Physical Aggression Policy (Hitting, Kicking, Pushing)

Physical aggression such as hitting, kicking, pushing, or throwing objects at others is addressed with the same trauma-informed, progressive approach.

- **First incident:** The caregiver intervenes immediately, separates the children, and uses emotion coaching. Both families are notified through an incident report.
- **Second incident (or emerging pattern):** The Director reviews documentation. Targeted strategies are implemented. A parent conference (Step 1) is scheduled.
- **Third incident or continued pattern:** A written behavior plan (Step 2) is developed with the family.
- **Persistent aggression after the plan is in place:** Temporary suspension (Step 3) and, if necessary, disenrollment (Step 4) may follow.

If a single incident results in serious injury, the center may require immediate parent pickup and begin the escalation process at Step 3 or Step 4.

SECTION 15: CHILD ABUSE AND NEGLECT REPORTING

IMPORTANT: Every employee of Benevolent House Academy is a mandatory reporter under Texas law. This means you are legally required to report suspected child abuse or neglect. Failure to report is a criminal offense.

How to Report

If you have reason to believe that a child has been or is being abused or neglected, you must report it immediately. Reports are made to:

- **Texas DFPS Abuse Hotline:** 1-800-252-5400 (available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week)
- **Online Reporting:** www.txabusehotline.org

Reports must be made within 48 hours of the time you first suspect abuse or neglect. You do not need to have proof. You do not need permission from the Director, Executive Director, or anyone else to make a report.

What to Report

- Physical abuse: unexplained bruises, burns, fractures, or injuries inconsistent with the explanation given
- Sexual abuse: any sexual contact or conduct involving a child
- Emotional abuse: persistent verbal attacks, threats, humiliation, or rejection
- Neglect: failure to provide adequate food, clothing, shelter, medical care, or supervision
- Any statement made by a child indicating they have been harmed

Protection from Retaliation

Texas law protects any person who reports suspected child abuse or neglect in good faith. Benevolent House Academy will not retaliate against any employee for making a good-faith report.

Internal Allegations

If the allegation involves an employee of Benevolent House Academy, the employee in question will be immediately removed from direct contact with children pending the outcome of the investigation. The Director and Executive Director will cooperate fully with DFPS and licensing investigators.

SECTION 16: HEALTH, SAFETY, AND SANITATION

Daily Safety Checks

Before children arrive each morning, a daily safety check is completed for all indoor and outdoor areas. This includes verifying that all exits are clear, electrical outlets are covered, cleaning supplies and hazardous materials are locked away, outdoor equipment is in good repair, the outdoor area is free of debris and standing water, all gates and fences are secure, floors are clean and free of tripping hazards, and all areas are adequately lit and ventilated. The daily safety check is documented using the BHA Daily Indoor Safety Check form and the BHA Daily Outdoor Safety Check form.

Handwashing

Proper handwashing is one of the most important things you will do every day. Handwashing procedures are posted at every sink. Children and staff wash hands with soap and running water upon arrival at the center, before and after eating meals or snacks, before and after preparing or serving food, after toileting or assisting a child with toileting, after diapering, after wiping a child's nose or handling bodily fluids, after outdoor play, after handling animals, and before and after administering medication.

Diapering

Diaper changing stations are located in the Seedlings (Classroom 0) and Discoverers (Classroom 1) rooms. Each station has a safety strap and is located near a handwashing sink. The full diapering procedure is posted at each changing station. Never leave a child unattended on the changing table. Clean the child from front to back. Dispose of the soiled diaper in the hands-free covered receptacle. Sanitize the changing surface after each use. Wash your hands thoroughly.

Sanitation Schedule

The center follows a daily, weekly, and monthly cleaning and sanitation schedule. Daily: sanitize tables before and after meals, sanitize diaper changing surfaces after each use, clean restrooms at least twice daily, sweep and mop floors, remove trash, sanitize toys mouthed by infants and toddlers. Weekly: deep clean floors, launder cot sheets and bedding, sanitize all toys, clean windows and low surfaces. Monthly: deep clean kitchen appliances, inspect and clean outdoor equipment, sanitize storage areas. The schedule is documented using the BHA Weekly Cleaning and Sanitation Schedule form.

Animals

Benevolent House Academy does not keep animals or pets at the center. No animals are permitted on the premises during operating hours except for a special educational activity, in which case parents will be notified in advance. All children wash their hands after any contact with animals.

Sunscreen and Insect Repellent

Benevolent House Academy does not provide sunscreen or insect repellent. If a parent would like the center to apply sunscreen or insect repellent to their child, the parent must provide the product labeled with the child's first and last name and complete a written authorization form. Only commercial, store-bought, EPA-registered products will be applied. The center will not apply homemade or unlabeled products.

Screen Time

Benevolent House Academy limits screen time in accordance with TAC 746.2207. Screen time is never used for children under 2 years of age. For children 2 years and older, screen time is educational, related to planned learning activities, no more than one hour per day, never used during meals, snacks, or rest, never a substitute for physical activity, outdoor play, or caregiver interaction, always supervised, and turned off when not in use. At BHA, the Explorers, Innovators, and Scholars classrooms may include up to 30 minutes of optional educational screen time near the end of the day. Any child under 2 in the Explorers classroom does a quiet alternative activity, such as books or puzzles, during that time.

Illness (Children)

If a child becomes ill during the day, the caregiver notifies the Director immediately. The child is separated from the group in a supervised area until the parent arrives for pickup. Parents are notified immediately through Brightwheel and by phone. Children with fever (100.4 degrees F or higher), vomiting, diarrhea, or other symptoms on the exclusion list must be picked up and may not return until symptom-free for 24 hours (without medication) or until cleared by a physician.

SECTION 17: EMPLOYEE ILLNESS POLICY

The health of our staff directly affects the health of the children in our care. Employees who are ill must not report to work.

When to Stay Home

Employees must not report to work if they are experiencing any of the following symptoms:

- Fever of 100.4 degrees F or higher
- Vomiting or diarrhea
- Persistent cough, especially if accompanied by fever

- Known or suspected contagious illness (strep throat, influenza, COVID-19, conjunctivitis/pink eye, ringworm, lice, scabies, or any condition on the DSHS Communicable Disease Chart)
- Open or draining skin sores that cannot be covered

Employees must notify the Director as early as possible if they will be absent due to illness. Employees may return to work when they have been symptom-free for at least 24 hours without the use of medication, or when cleared by a physician.

Illness Absences Are Unpaid

All illness-related absences are unpaid. Benevolent House Academy does not currently offer paid sick leave (see Section 6: Paid Time Off). This policy will be revisited as the center grows.

Doctor's Note Requirements

A doctor's note is required in the following situations:

- The employee has been absent for 3 or more consecutive scheduled workdays due to illness. The note must confirm the employee was seen by a physician and is cleared to return to work.
- The employee was absent due to a known or suspected contagious illness (strep throat, influenza, COVID-19, conjunctivitis, ringworm, lice, scabies, or any condition on the DSHS Communicable Disease Chart). A return-to-work clearance from a physician is required regardless of the number of days missed.
- The Director has a reasonable concern about the employee's fitness to safely perform their duties. In this case, the Director may require a doctor's note before the employee returns.

Voluntary Abandonment

If an employee is absent for 5 or more consecutive scheduled workdays without providing a doctor's note and without maintaining communication with the Director, the employee will be considered to have voluntarily abandoned their position. Employment will be terminated, and the employee will be notified in writing. This provision does not apply if the employee has been in regular communication with the Director and has a documented medical reason for the absence.

Illness During a Shift

If an employee becomes ill during their shift, they must notify the Director immediately. The Director will arrange for coverage so the employee can leave. Employees are not penalized for staying home when genuinely ill. However, patterns of suspicious absences (such as repeated Friday or Monday absences, or absences coinciding with denied time-off requests) may be addressed through the corrective action process.

SECTION 18: EMERGENCY PROCEDURES

Benevolent House Academy maintains a comprehensive Emergency Preparedness Plan that addresses fire, severe weather, lockdown, medical emergencies, and facility evacuation. A copy of the full plan is posted in the center and reviewed with every employee during orientation and at least annually.

Key Points

- **Fire:** Fire drills are conducted monthly. Evacuation routes are posted in every room. Know your route and your meeting point. Fire extinguishers are located throughout the building. A head count is conducted immediately after evacuation.
- **Severe Weather:** Severe weather drills (tornado/storm) are conducted quarterly. The designated indoor shelter areas are the interior hallway and interior rooms away from windows. A weather radio is maintained at the center.
- **Lockdown:** Lockdown drills are conducted quarterly. In the event of a threat, all exterior doors are secured, children are moved away from windows and doors, a head count is verified, 911 is contacted, and staff remain in lockdown until cleared by law enforcement.
- **Medical Emergency:** Administer first aid (if trained). Call 911 for life-threatening situations. Notify the Director. Notify the parent immediately. Complete an incident report.

Designated Relocation Sites

If the building must be evacuated and cannot be reoccupied, all children and staff will relocate to a designated relocation site. Whenever the emergency allows, staff walk the children to Benevolent House next door first:

- Benevolent House, 504 SH-342, Red Oak, TX 75154 (primary relocation site, located next door, day or night)
- Red Oak Fire Department, 111 Live Oak Street, Red Oak, TX 75154 (offsite relocation site, day or night)

If Benevolent House is not safe or available, the group relocates to the Red Oak Fire Department. The Director or designee chooses the site based on the nature, location, and timing of the emergency. Emergency records for all children travel with the group in the Emergency Bag. Parents are notified immediately through Brightwheel and phone calls with the specific relocation address.

IMPORTANT: Every employee is expected to know the evacuation route from their assigned classroom, the location of fire extinguishers and first aid kits, the designated severe weather shelter areas, and all relocation site addresses. These are reviewed during orientation and during every drill.

SECTION 19: INCLEMENT WEATHER AND EMERGENCY CLOSURES

Benevolent House Academy follows Red Oak ISD for weather closures and delayed openings. If Red Oak ISD closes due to weather, BHA is closed. If Red Oak ISD delays its start, BHA opens at the same time Red Oak ISD schools open that day. The center may also close temporarily due to power outages, water main breaks, or other emergencies that make it unsafe to operate. Employees are notified as early as possible through Brightwheel staff messaging,

text message, and/or phone call from the Director or Executive Director. Families are notified through Brightwheel.

Compensation During Closures

Emergency closure days are unpaid for hourly employees. Salaried employees will be paid as normal during closures of fewer than 5 consecutive business days. If a closure extends 5 or more consecutive business days, the Executive Director will evaluate the situation and communicate with all employees regarding compensation.

Employee Expectations

If the center is open but an employee feels unsafe traveling to work due to weather conditions, the employee must contact the Director as soon as possible. The absence will be unpaid. Employees should use their best judgment regarding personal safety, but frequent weather-related absences when the center is open may be addressed through the attendance policy.

SECTION 20: MEDICATION ADMINISTRATION

Medication is administered only with written parental authorization and only as directed on the label and by a physician's written instructions, when applicable. The parent must complete a medication authorization form that includes the child's name, medication name, dosage, time and method of administration, and any special instructions.

Medication Storage and Administration Rules

- All medications must be in the original, labeled container with the child's name.
- Prescription medication is administered only as directed on the label and in accordance with the physician's written instructions.
- Medications are stored in a dedicated medication storage area in the office, out of reach of children. Medications requiring refrigeration are stored in a small dedicated refrigerator in the office, separate from food items.
- Before administering medication, the caregiver verifies the child's identity, medication name, dosage, time, and route.
- A medication administration log is maintained that records the child's name, medication name, dosage given, time administered, and the name of the caregiver who administered it.
- Medications are returned to the parent when no longer needed. Expired medications are removed from storage immediately and returned to the parent. If the parent cannot be reached, expired medications are disposed of in accordance with safe disposal practices.
- No over-the-counter medication is administered without written parental authorization and labeled instructions.
- Products treated as medication. Diaper cream, ointments, medicated lotion, teething gel, antibiotic ointment, hydrocortisone, sunscreen, and insect repellent are handled as medication. Each requires a signed authorization form and must be in its original

container labeled with the child's first and last name, and is applied only at or below the dosing, frequency, and age instructions on the label (TAC 746.3803(c)).

- Not administered. BHA does not give over-the-counter fever reducers (such as acetaminophen or ibuprofen) or cough and cold medications. A child who needs these is sent home under the illness policy.
- Not permitted at any age. Essential oils, vapor rubs, aromatherapy products, medicated patches, and wearable or clip-on diffusers are not applied or allowed, even with parent authorization or a physician order.
- Exceptions. Staff do not approve exceptions at the door. Parents submit exception requests in writing through Brightwheel to the BHA leadership team. Refer any parent question to the Director.

Medication Safety Plan

If a child requires ongoing or emergency medication (such as an epinephrine auto-injector, inhaler, or seizure medication), the parent and the Director will develop a written medication safety plan that includes the condition, triggers, medication details, administration instructions, and emergency response steps. The plan is kept in the child's file and a copy is posted in the child's classroom (accessible to staff, not visible to other families).

Unable to Reach Parent Regarding Medication

If a question or concern arises regarding a child's medication and the center is unable to reach the parent after three (3) contact attempts (phone call to parent, then to each emergency contact on file), the center will contact Poison Control at 1-800-222-1222 for guidance. In a medical emergency, 911 will be called immediately regardless of whether the parent has been reached. Parent authorization is not required to administer medication in a medical emergency to prevent the death or serious bodily injury of a child, per TAC 746.3803(d).

Epinephrine Auto-Injectors

Benevolent House Academy does not maintain an unassigned epinephrine auto-injector at this time. If a child has a known risk of anaphylaxis, the parent must provide a current, unexpired, prescribed epinephrine auto-injector with a completed medication authorization form and a food allergy emergency plan.

SECTION 21: TRANSPORTATION

Benevolent House Academy does not currently provide routine transportation. If children are transported, such as during an emergency relocation or a future school-age summer field trip, employees who drive or ride along must complete the required transportation safety training (TAC 746.1316) and comply with the following:

- Each child must have written parental authorization for transportation on file.
- Children must be secured in age-appropriate safety restraints at all times.
- A name-to-face head count is conducted before departure and upon arrival at every destination using the BHA Vehicle Transportation Log/Roster.

- Before each trip, the driver completes the BHA Vehicle Pre-Trip Inspection Checklist.
- After all children have exited the vehicle, the driver must visually inspect the entire vehicle interior (including under seats and the back of the vehicle) to ensure no child has been left behind. This check is documented each time.
- No child is ever left unattended in a vehicle.
- The vehicle is properly maintained, insured, and inspected.
- A charged cell phone is carried for emergencies.
- A first aid kit is available in the vehicle.

IMPORTANT: The visual vehicle check after unloading is not optional. It must be completed and documented every single time children exit the vehicle, without exception.

Transportation Emergencies

In the event of a transportation emergency (vehicle breakdown, accident, or medical emergency during transport), the following procedures apply:

- The driver or accompanying caregiver calls 911 immediately if there is an injury or imminent danger.
- All children remain secured in the vehicle unless the vehicle is unsafe (fire, smoke, or structural damage), in which case children are moved to a safe location away from traffic.
- The driver contacts the Director immediately to report the situation.
- The Director arranges for a replacement vehicle or alternate transportation and notifies parents of all children being transported.
- A head count is conducted immediately and continuously until all children are accounted for and safely returned to the center or released to their parents.
- An incident report is completed for every transportation emergency.

SECTION 22: TRAINING REQUIREMENTS

Texas licensing requires all childcare employees to complete training annually. Benevolent House Academy tracks all training hours using the BHA Staff Training Log (Appendix C) and maintains documentation in each employee's personnel file.

Preservice Training

Caregivers who are not exempt must complete 24 clock hours of pre-service training: 8 clock hours before being counted in the child-to-caregiver ratio, and the remaining 16 clock hours within 90 days of employment (TAC 746.1301 and 746.1305). Caregivers with at least two years of experience in a regulated child-care center, or with documentation of 24 clock hours of pre-service training from another regulated center, are exempt (TAC 746.1307).

Annual Training Requirements

- **Caregivers:** Minimum of 24 clock hours of training per year.

- **Director:** Minimum of 30 clock hours of training per year.

Annual training is separate from orientation, pre-service training, and pediatric first aid and CPR. It is completed within 12 months of each employee's date of hire and during each 12-month period after that (TAC 746.1313), and extra hours do not carry over. Training is obtained through in-house sessions, approved online courses, and community workshops.

Training Types and Requirements (TAC 746.1309)

- **Instructor-Led Training:** Live training with direct interaction. A minimum of 20% of each employee's annual training hours must be instructor-led.
- **Self-Instructional Training:** Standardized training completed at the employee's own pace through an approved online provider, with built-in assessments.
- **Self-Study Training:** Non-standardized training such as reading articles or watching recorded webinars. May not exceed 3 clock hours per training year (TAC 746.123).

Training Documentation (TAC 746.1329)

Original training certificates or letters must be maintained in each employee's personnel file. Each certificate must include the employee's name, training topic, date, trainer's name and qualifications, and the number of clock hours or CEUs earned. CPR and First Aid certificates must also include the expiration date.

CPR and First Aid

At least one caregiver with current CPR and First Aid certification must be present at the center at all times during hours of operation. The center encourages all caregivers to obtain and maintain CPR and First Aid certification. Certification costs are covered by the center.

Additional Training for Infant Caregivers

Caregivers assigned to the Seedlings (infant) room must complete at least one hour of preservice training specific to infant care, including prevention of Sudden Infant Death Syndrome (SIDS), shaken baby syndrome/abusive head trauma, and early brain development.

SECTION 23: SOCIAL MEDIA POLICY

Employees are prohibited from posting any photographs, videos, names, or identifying information about children enrolled at Benevolent House Academy on any personal social media platform. This includes Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, Snapchat, X (Twitter), and YouTube. Employees may not post negative or disparaging comments about the center, its families, coworkers, or leadership on social media. Official BHA social media accounts are managed only by individuals authorized by the Executive Director. Any content featuring children requires prior written parental consent. Violation of this policy is grounds for immediate termination.

SECTION 24: STAFF BENEFITS AND INCENTIVES

Staff Childcare Discount

Benevolent House Academy recognizes that many of our employees are also parents. Eligible employees may enroll their children at the center at a discounted tuition rate. Specific discount amounts and eligibility requirements are provided at the time of hire and are subject to available space and enrollment capacity. Staff childcare enrollment is subject to the same policies, procedures, and documentation requirements as all other enrolled families. The staff childcare discount is a benefit of employment and is not transferable. The discount ends when employment ends.

Staff Incentives

Benevolent House Academy offers the following incentives to recognize the employees who make safe, consistent care possible. The incentive program began October 1, 2026. Time worked before that date counts toward each employee's probationary period and milestone dates, and October through December 2026 is the first quarter counted for earned paid days. Incentives are tracked by the BHA leadership team.

Earned Paid Days

Caregiver and support staff positions earn one paid day off (a day off with regular pay, not a cash payout) for each calendar quarter (January to March, April to June, July to September, October to December) with no no-call/no-shows and no more than two tardies, up to four paid days per year. Director positions receive PTO instead (see Section 6). Everyone follows the same calendar quarters. An employee is eligible for a quarter if their 90-day probationary period has ended by the first day of that quarter. Only two things count: tardies and no-call/no-shows. A tardy means clocking in to Brightwheel more than 5 minutes after your scheduled start time (see Section 4). Clocking in 1 to 5 minutes late is not a tardy. Calling out ahead of time does not count against the earned paid day. Reasons for a tardy are not weighed; the allowance of two tardies each quarter is there for the unexpected, such as car trouble or a sick child. Legally protected absences, such as jury duty or an approved accommodation, are never counted against an employee. Earned paid days are awarded in the first week after each quarter ends and must be used by December 31 of the year they are awarded. They are requested in writing at least two weeks in advance and approved based on staffing and ratios. Unused days do not carry over and are not paid out at separation.

How it works in real life: If you are sick, your child is sick, or your car breaks down and you call out at least one hour before your shift (see Section 4), it does not count against you. If you come in but clock in more than 5 minutes late, for any reason, it counts as one tardy. You can have up to 2 tardies in a quarter and still earn the day; a third tardy means that quarter's day is not earned, and you start fresh the next quarter. A no-call/no-show means that quarter's day is not earned. Clocking in 1 to 5 minutes late never counts. Letting a director know you are running late is appreciated, but clocking in more than 5 minutes late still counts as a tardy. If you forget to clock in, tell a director right away so your arrival time can be confirmed and entered. Tardies are measured against the start time on your posted schedule for that day, and only the clock-in at the start of your shift counts, not returning from lunch or leaving at the end of the day. The earned paid day is separate from the tardiness policy in Section 4, which still applies. Absences you call out for never count, no matter how many days you are out. If an emergency, such as a hospital stay, keeps you or a family member from calling, let a director know as soon as you are able, and it will not be treated as a no-call/no-show. Approved time off, center closures, and jury duty never count.

The schedule below shows how the quarters work. Each year follows the same pattern.

Quarter (attendance counted)	Must be hired on or before	Reviewed and awarded	Must be used by
October 1 to December 31, 2026	July 3, 2026	First week of January 2027	December 31, 2027
January 1 to March 31, 2027	October 3, 2026	First week of April 2027	December 31, 2027
April 1 to June 30, 2027	January 1, 2027	First week of July 2027	December 31, 2027
July 1 to September 30, 2027	April 2, 2027	First week of October 2027	December 31, 2027
October 1 to December 31, 2027	July 3, 2027	First week of January 2028	December 31, 2028

"Must be hired on or before" means the 90-day probationary period has ended by the first day of that quarter. Bonuses (milestone, anniversary, and referral bonuses) are paid in money; earned paid days are time off with pay.

Milestone and Anniversary Bonuses

All employees, including director positions, receive the following bonuses, paid as a separate bonus check through payroll on the next payday after each milestone: \$100 at 6 months of continuous employment; \$250 at 1 year; \$250 on every work anniversary after that; and \$500 on every 5-year anniversary (5, 10, 15 years, and so on). Milestones are counted from the original BHA hire date, and only milestones reached on or after October 1, 2026 are paid. The employee must be actively employed on the milestone date.

Staff Referral Bonus

An employee who refers a new caregiver receives a \$100 bonus once the new caregiver completes the 90-day probationary period, paid as a separate bonus check through payroll on the next payday. Both the referring employee and the new caregiver must be actively employed at that time. The new caregiver must name the referring employee on their application.

Incentives are subject to change and do not alter the at-will nature of employment.

SECTION 25: WORKPLACE VIOLENCE PREVENTION

Benevolent House Academy is committed to providing a safe workplace for all employees, children, and families. The center has zero tolerance for violence, threats of violence, intimidation, bullying, or any behavior that creates a hostile or unsafe environment.

Prohibited Conduct

- Physical violence of any kind (hitting, pushing, shoving, kicking, throwing objects).
- Threats of violence, whether verbal, written, or communicated through gestures or electronic means.
- Intimidation, bullying, or harassment directed at any employee, parent, child, or visitor.
- Possession of weapons (firearms, knives, or any other weapon) on center property or in center vehicles, regardless of whether the individual holds a concealed carry permit. The only exception is law enforcement officers acting in their official capacity.
- Destroying or damaging center property or the personal property of others.

Reporting

Any employee who experiences, witnesses, or becomes aware of workplace violence or threats must report it immediately to the Director or Executive Director. If there is an imminent threat of harm, call 911 first, then notify the Director. All reports will be investigated promptly. Retaliation against any employee who reports workplace violence in good faith is prohibited.

SECTION 26: FRATERNIZATION AND WORKPLACE RELATIONSHIPS

Benevolent House Academy recognizes that employees may develop personal friendships and, in some cases, romantic relationships with coworkers. However, workplace relationships must not interfere with job performance, create a conflict of interest, or affect the professional environment of the center.

- Romantic or dating relationships between a supervisor and a direct report are prohibited.
- Personal relationships must not result in favoritism or the perception of favoritism in scheduling, assignments, evaluations, or any other employment decision.
- Public displays of affection between employees are not permitted on center premises or during work hours.
- Personal conflicts between employees must not be brought into the workplace or allowed to affect the care of children.

SECTION 27: GRIEVANCE AND COMPLAINT PROCEDURE

Benevolent House Academy encourages open communication and wants every employee to feel comfortable raising concerns, questions, or complaints about workplace conditions, policies, or treatment. Employees will not face retaliation for raising a concern in good faith.

How to Raise a Concern

- **Step 1:** Speak with the Director. Most concerns can be resolved through a direct conversation. The Director will listen, investigate if needed, and respond within 5 business days.
- **Step 2:** If the concern is not resolved, or if the concern involves the Director, the employee may submit a written complaint to the Executive Director (Tanya Orr) by email or in a sealed envelope marked "Confidential." The Executive Director will investigate and respond within 10 business days.
- **Step 3:** If the concern involves a potential violation of law, licensing standards, or child safety, the employee may also contact HHSC Child Care Regulation directly at 1-800-582-6036 or DFPS at 1-800-252-5400. Employees are never required to exhaust internal procedures before contacting a regulatory agency.

All grievances and complaints will be handled as confidentially as possible. Retaliation against any employee who files a grievance or participates in an investigation is strictly prohibited.

SECTION 28: CORRECTIVE ACTION AND TERMINATION

Progressive Corrective Action

Benevolent House Academy generally follows a progressive corrective action process:

- **Step 1: Verbal Warning.** A verbal discussion documented in the employee's file.

- **Step 2: Written Warning.** A formal written notice describing the issue, the expected correction, and the timeline for improvement.
- **Step 3: Final Written Warning / Suspension.** A final written warning with or without suspension (3 days without pay). The employee is advised that further violations will result in termination.
- **Step 4: Termination.** If the issue is not resolved, employment is terminated.

Immediate Termination

Some offenses are so serious that they warrant immediate termination without progressive steps. These include:

- Any form of child abuse, neglect, or prohibited discipline
- Failure to report suspected child abuse or neglect
- Being under the influence of drugs or alcohol while on duty
- Leaving children unsupervised
- Falsifying records (time records, background check information, training records, or any other official document)
- Theft of center property or personal property of others
- Violation of the confidentiality or photography policy involving children
- Physical altercation or fighting with a coworker, parent, or visitor
- Yelling, screaming, or shouting at a coworker, parent, child, or visitor in anger or hostility
- Using profanity, curse words, or vulgar language in the workplace at any time
- Gossiping about coworkers, families, or children (spreading rumors, sharing personal information, making negative comments behind someone's back, or creating division)
- A no-call, no-show
- Any conduct that puts children at risk of harm

Voluntary Resignation

Employees who wish to resign are asked to provide at least two weeks of written notice. This allows the center adequate time to arrange coverage and maintain safe ratios. Employees who resign without notice may not be eligible for rehire.

SECTION 29: ACKNOWLEDGMENT OF RECEIPT

I, the undersigned, acknowledge that I have received a copy of the Benevolent House Academy Employee Handbook (revised October 2026). I understand that it is my responsibility to read, understand, and comply with the policies and procedures described in this handbook.

I understand that this handbook is not a contract of employment. My employment with Benevolent House Academy is at-will, meaning that either I or the employer may end the employment relationship at any time, with or without cause, and with or without notice.

I understand that Benevolent House Academy reserves the right to modify, amend, or update the policies in this handbook at any time. I will be notified of any changes and will receive an updated copy.

I understand that violation of the policies in this handbook may result in corrective action up to and including termination of employment.

A separate signature page is provided for employee acknowledgment and is maintained in the employee's personnel file.

Appendices

The following forms are referenced throughout this handbook and are provided to each employee at the time of hire. Blank copies are maintained at the center at all times.

Appendix A: New Employee Orientation Checklist. Completed within the first 7 calendar days of hire.

Appendix B: Employee Acknowledgment of Policies. Completed on or before the first day working with children.

Appendix C: Staff Training Log. Updated throughout the training year as training is completed.

ADDITIONAL EMPLOYEE REFERENCE POLICIES

Outside Food Policy

As a general practice, outside food is not permitted at Benevolent House Academy. The center provides all meals and snacks through the CACFP. If a child has a documented sensory need, religious dietary requirement, or health-based or medical dietary need that cannot be accommodated by the center's menu, the parent may request to provide the child's meals and snacks from home. In accordance with TAC 746.3309(a), the enrollment agreement or an addendum signed by the parent must include a statement that: (1) the parent is choosing to provide the child's meals and snacks from home; and (2) the parent understands the child-care center is not responsible for its nutritional value or for meeting the child's daily food needs. All parent-provided food must be labeled with the child's first and last name and date. Benevolent House Academy is an egg and nut free facility. Food brought into the building for children, including celebration treats, must not contain eggs, peanuts, or tree nuts.

Safe Sleep Policy (Infants)

This policy applies to all infants from 6 weeks through 12 months of age. Infants are always placed on their backs to sleep. Infants sleep in individual, safety-approved cribs that meet CPSC standards. Cribs contain a firm mattress and a fitted sheet only. No blankets, pillows, bumper pads, quilts, stuffed animals, toys, sleep positioners, loose sheets, attached pacifiers, pacifiers with clips, cords, or hooks, or any other soft objects or restrictive devices are allowed in the crib. Infants are never placed to sleep in swings, bouncers, car seats, or any device that is not a safety-approved crib. Infants who fall asleep in a location other than their crib are moved to their crib immediately. Swaddling is not permitted at the center. Caregivers visually check on sleeping infants frequently.